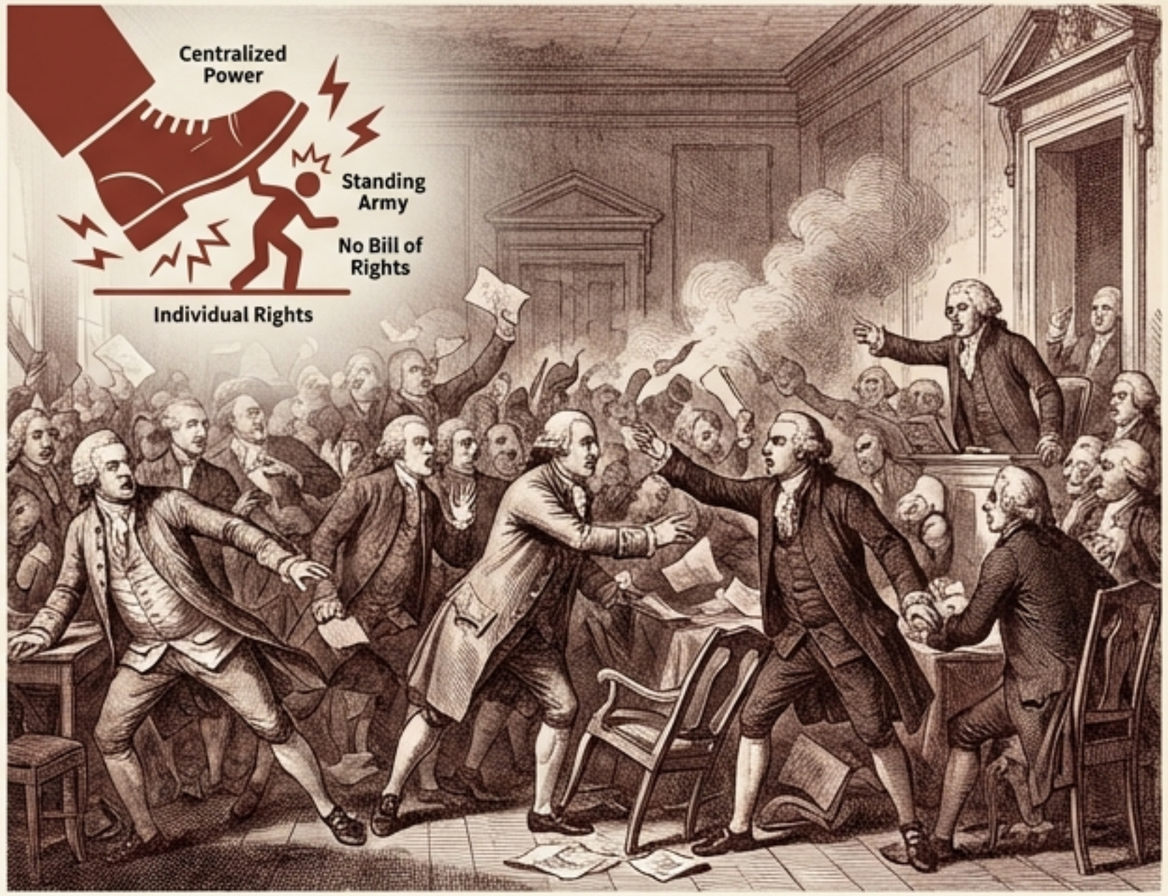
FEDERALISTS: THE VISION OF ORDER & STRENGTH

ANTIFEDERALISTS: THE FEAR OF TYRANNY & LOSS OF LIBERTY



Proposed Government: A unified, streng central government to ensure stablity, defense, and economic prosperity. Supported by Alexander Hamilton, James Madison, John Jay.

A MORE PERFECT UNION: THE BATTLE FOR RATIFICATION

Federalists, Antifederalists, and the Birth of the Bill of Rights (1787–1791)

Opposition & Fears: Concerns over excessive central power, threat to individual liberties, and lack of explicit protections. Led by Patrick Henry, George Mason, Samuel Adams.

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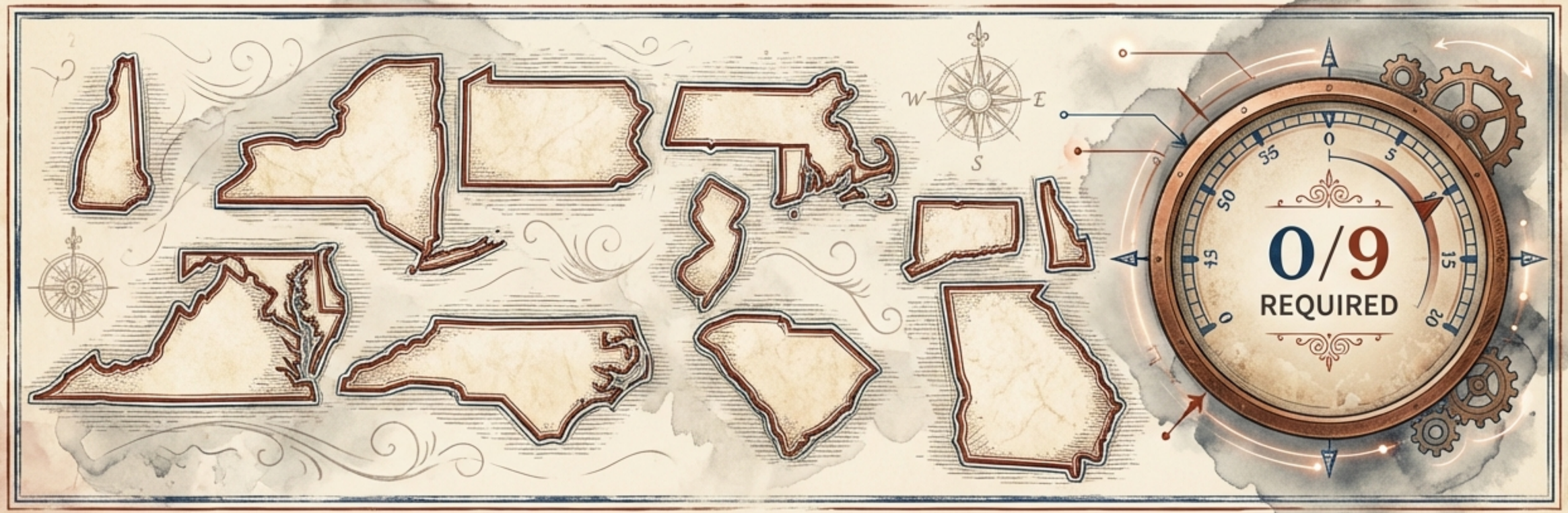
The Fate of the Nation Rested on Nine States

When the framers sent the Constitution to Congress, its future was uncertain. They established a specific process for ratification: voters in each state would elect delegates to special state conventions to decide the nation's fate.

KEY RULE: The Constitution would only go into effect when at least 9 of the 13 states ratified it.



"It will promote the lasting welfare of that country so dear to us all." — *George Washington*

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Two Visions for America's Future

THE FEDERALISTS

The Case for Order

Supporters of the Constitution.

Argued that the Articles of Confederation left too much power with individual states, resulting in a dangerously weak central government.

Favored a strong national government to manage disputes and function effectively.

THE ANTIFEDERALISTS

The Case for Liberty

Opponents of the Constitution.

Feared the new plan made the national government too strong and left states too weak.

Primary fear: The concentration of power in a central authority reminiscent of a monarchy.

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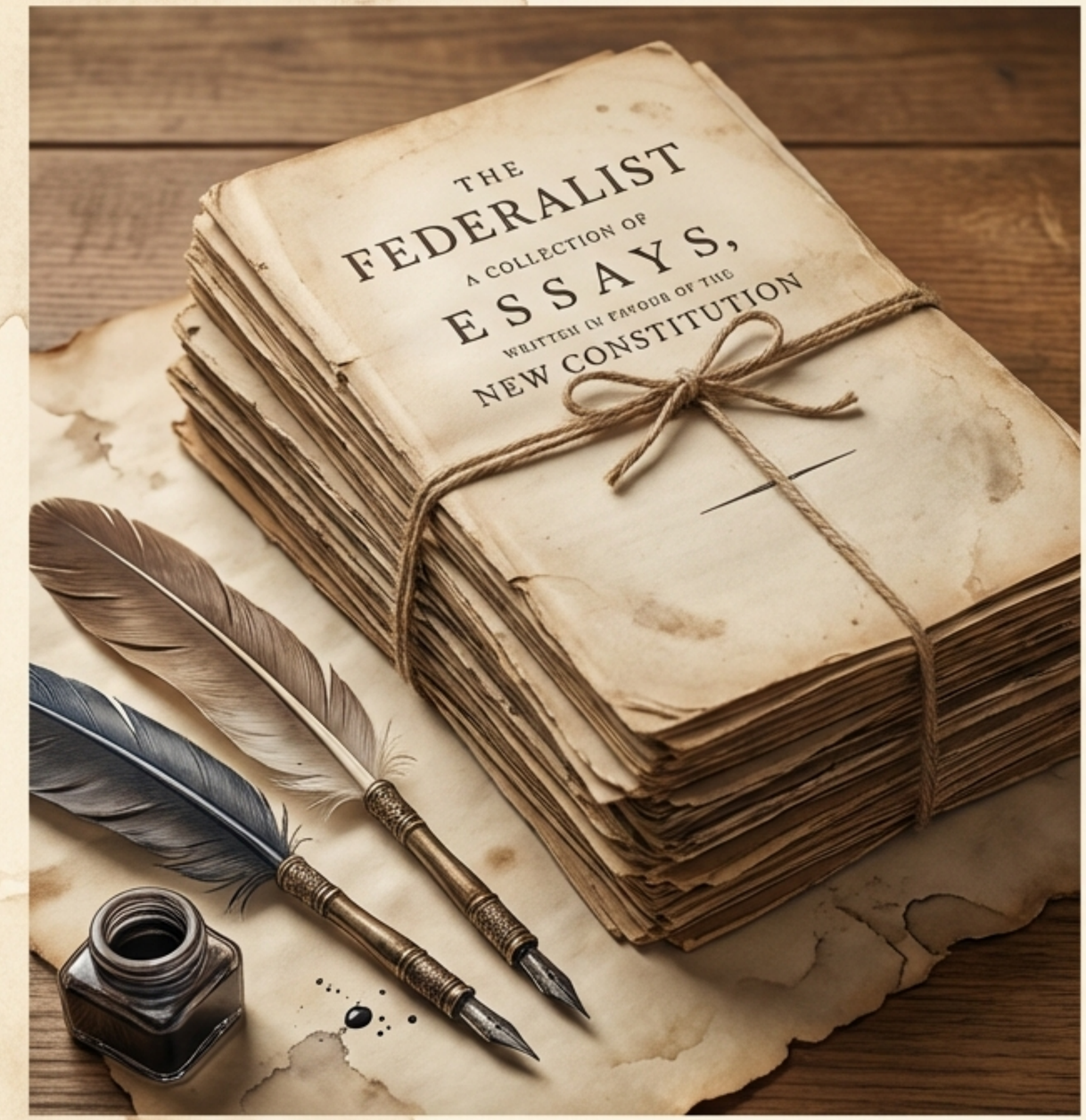

The Case for Efficiency and Stability

Federalists argued that while the new Constitution gave the government necessary authority, it still protected the rights of individual states.

THE KEY ASSET: The Federalist Papers

Written by James Madison, Alexander Hamilton, and John Jay under pen names, these essays explained and defended the political theory of the new system.

LEGACY:

These texts remain so influential that U.S. courts still refer to them today when making decisions about the principles of government.

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The Fear of a “President-King”

Antifederalists warned that the Constitution gave the President excessive power. While they admired George Washington, they feared future leaders might lack his honor.

KEY ARGUMENT:

Under the new system, the President had veto power over Congress—the people’s representatives.
To the Antifederalists, this looked like the tyranny they had just fought a revolution to escape.

“Your President may become king... If your American chief be a man of ambition and abilities, how easy is it for him to render himself absolute!”
— Patrick Henry, June 1788

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The “Horribly Frightful” Omission

THE GRIEVANCE:

“George Mason, author of Virginia’s own bill of rights, joined the Antifederalists because the Constitutional Convention refused to include one. His pamphlet opened with the direct accusation: “There is no Declaration of Rights.””

THE ARGUMENT:

Antifederalists argued that without spelling out basic liberties (speech, religion), a powerful government could easily ignore them. They pointed out that violations of these specific freedoms were the main grievances in the Declaration of Independence.

FEDERALIST REBUTTAL:

They claimed it was impossible to list all natural rights and that the Constitution itself was protection enough.

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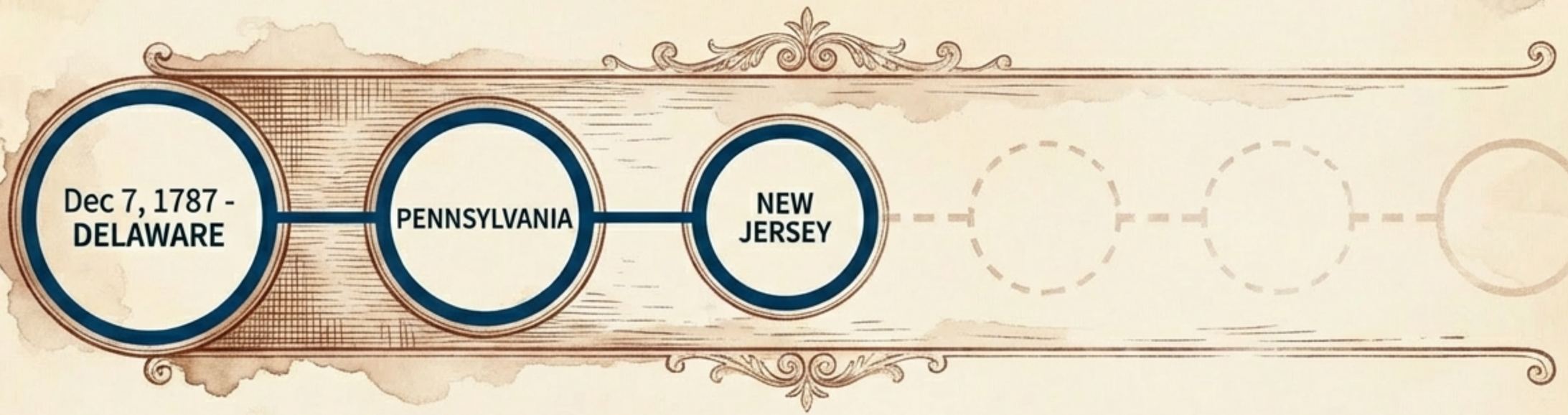
The Race to Nine Begins



Delaware leads the way as the first to ratify, with Pennsylvania and New Jersey following shortly after.

INSIGHT: In these early states, Federalists successfully convinced the majority of delegates that the Constitution represented a vast improvement over the chaotic Articles of Confederation.

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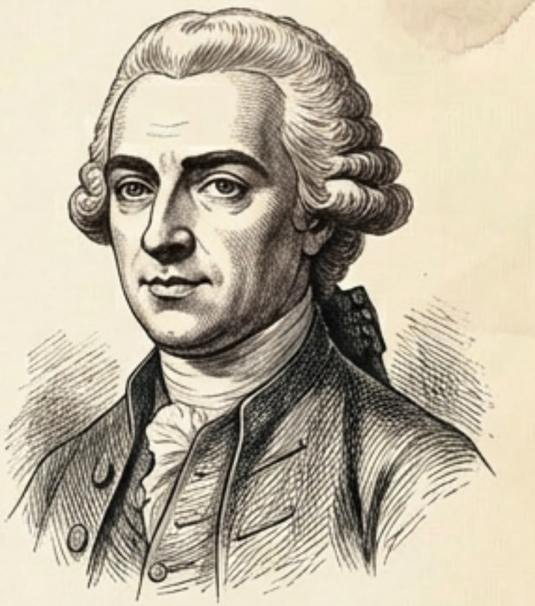
The Massachusetts Compromise

The Holdouts



THE CONFLICT: Massachusetts was the first key battleground. Adams and Hancock held back support, causing a delay Madison called "very ominous."

THE SOLUTION:
Adams and Hancock finally agreed to ratify only on the condition that the convention recommend adding a bill of rights. In February 1788, Massachusetts became the sixth state.

"Don't take a leap in the dark... gather fruit when it is ripe."

— A Federalist Farmer urging caution

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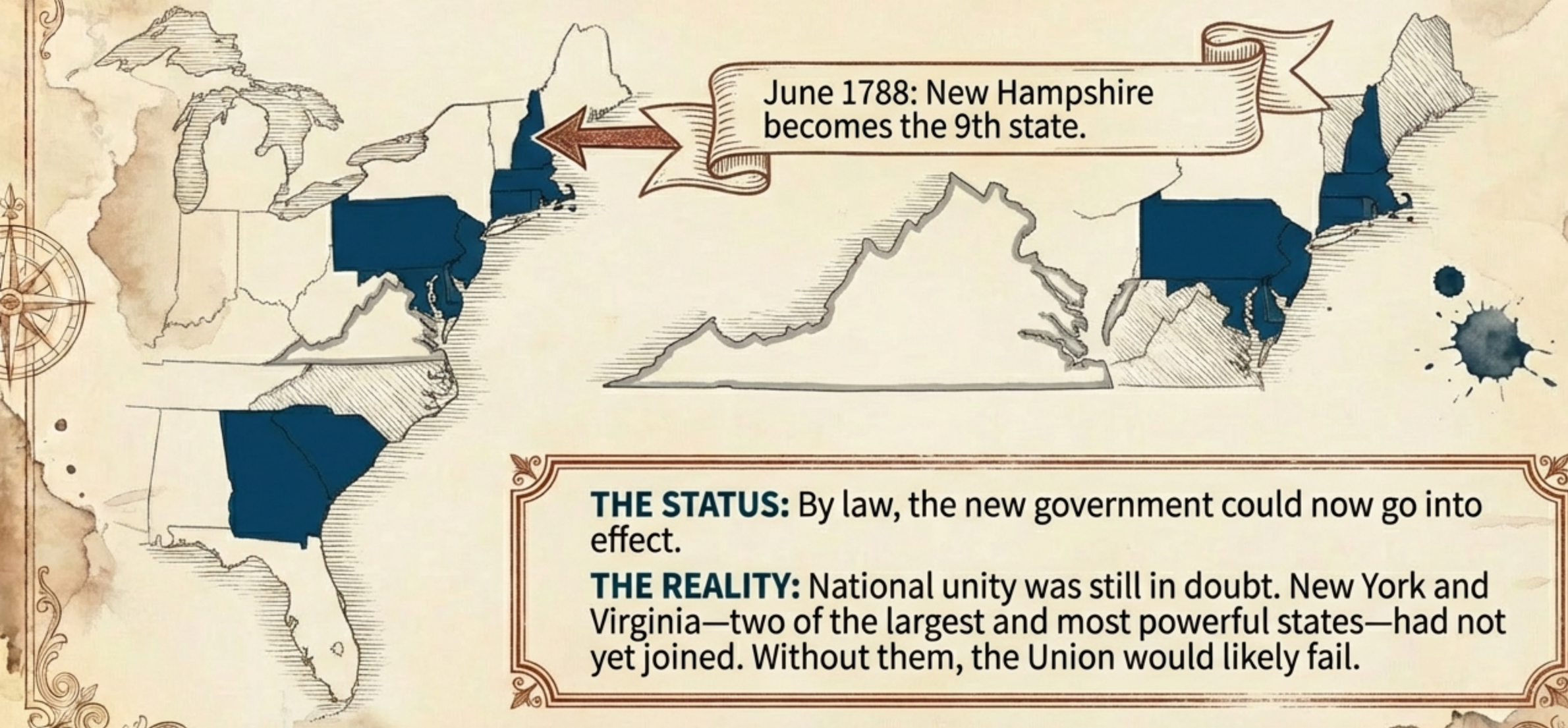
Technically Legal, Politically Fragile



THE STATUS: By law, the new government could now go into effect.

THE REALITY: National unity was still in doubt. New York and Virginia—two of the largest and most powerful states—had not yet joined. Without them, the Union would likely fail.

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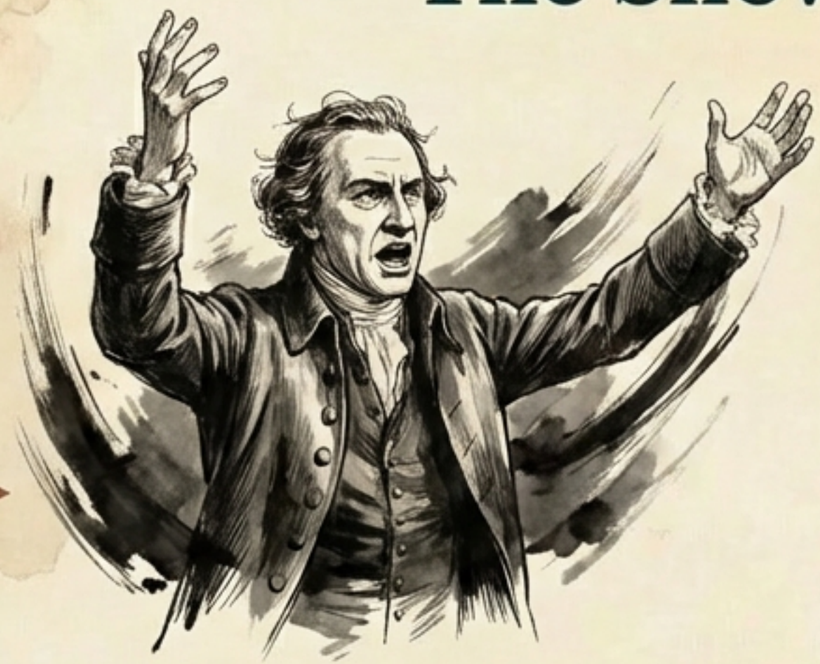
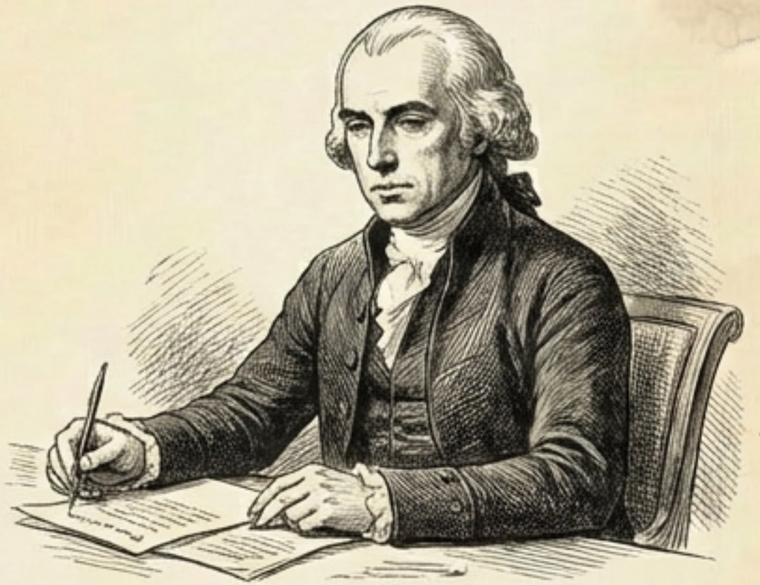
The Showdown in Virginia



THE ORATOR

Patrick Henry spoke for seven hours at one point against the plan. His style was spellbinding and dramatic.



THE ARCHITECT

James Madison, soft-spoken, countered with arguments that were clear, patient, and to the point.

THE TURN: Governor Edmund Randolph swung the vote only after Federalists promised to support a bill of rights. Virginia ratified in late June 1788.

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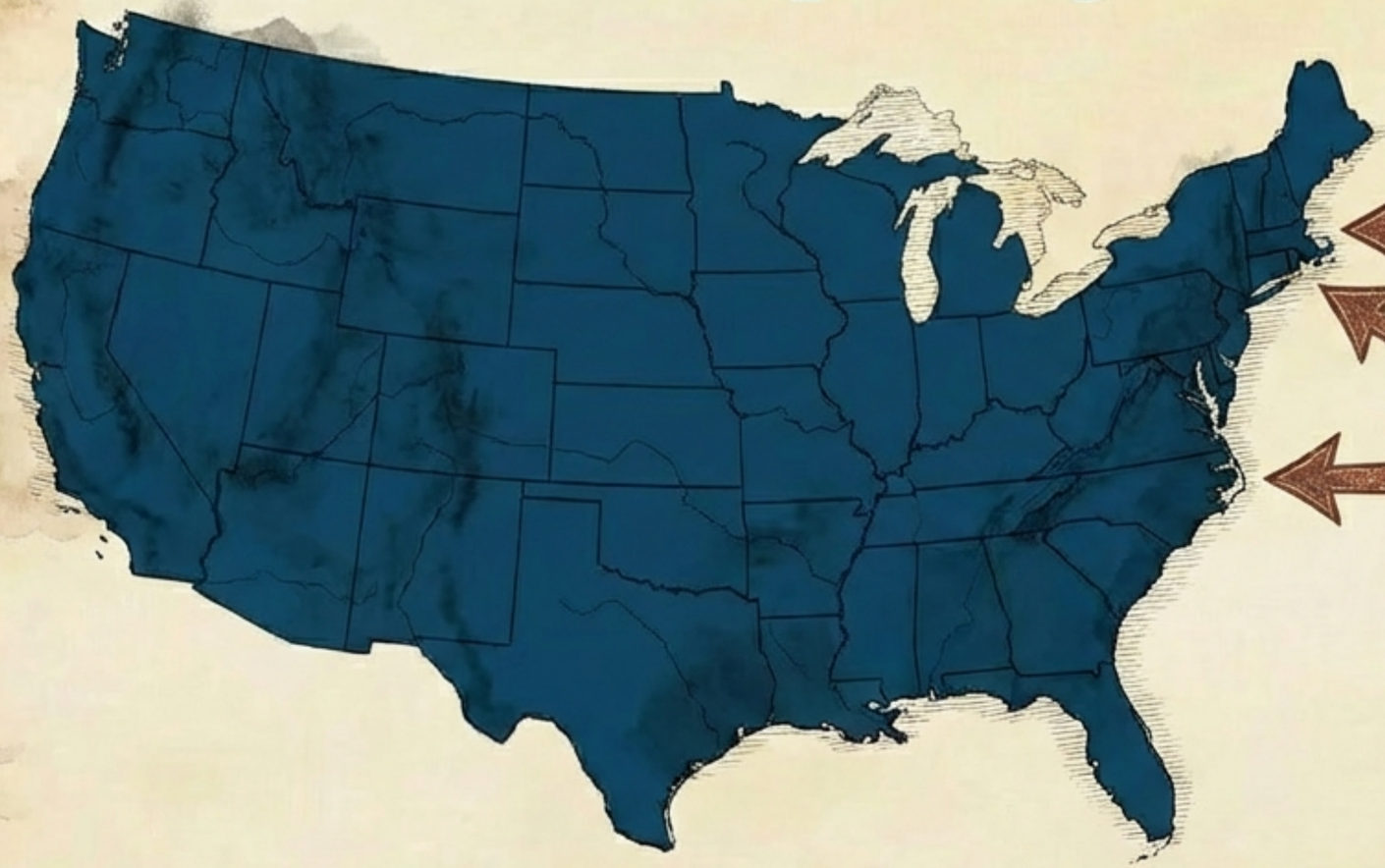
Completing the Map



NEW YORK:
Ratified July 1788
(After a struggle lasting a month longer than Virginia's).

NORTH CAROLINA:
Ratified November 1789.

RHODE ISLAND:
Ratified May 29, 1790
(Had refused to even send delegates to the Convention).

The United States was physically and legally complete.

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‘Tis Done. We Have Become a Nation.

July 4, 1788: Philadelphia throws a massive festival. Soldiers led a parade along Market Street to celebrate the ratification.

Quote: Benjamin Rush, a strong supporter, wrote to a friend declaring the nation was officially born.

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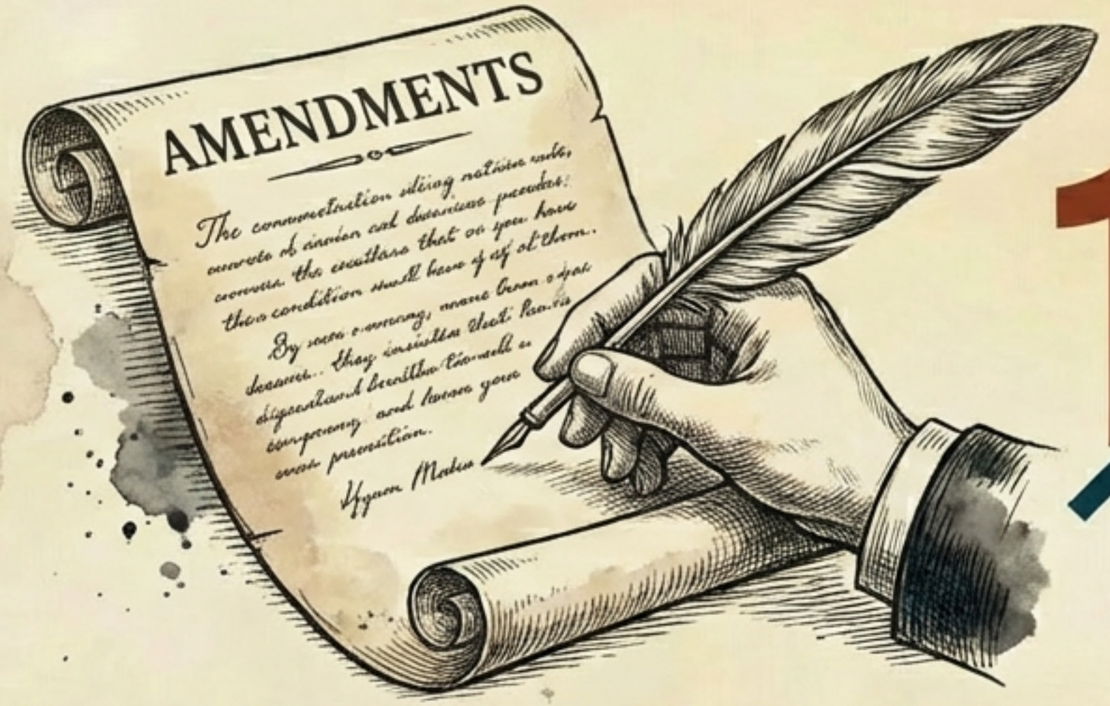
Keeping the Promise



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THE ACTION: In 1789, the First Congress met in New York City. James Madison wrote 12 amendments to satisfy the states that ratified on condition of a bill of rights. By December 1791, the states ratified 10 of them.

MADISON'S PHILOSOPHY: He insisted the Bill of Rights did not GIVE rights (which are natural); they simply prevented government from TAKING them.

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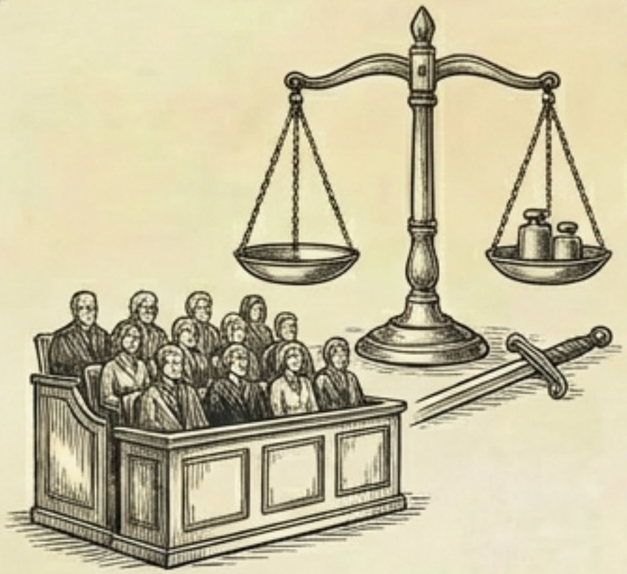
Inside the Bill of Rights

3rd AMENDMENT

3rd AMENDMENT:
Forbids quartering troops in homes without without consent
(A direct response to British abuse).



6th & 7th AMENDMENTS:
Guarantee the right to trial by jury

(Condemning the King's suspension of this right).

1st AMENDMENT:
Protects speech and religion.
Directly influenced by the 1786 Virginia Statute of Religious Freedom.

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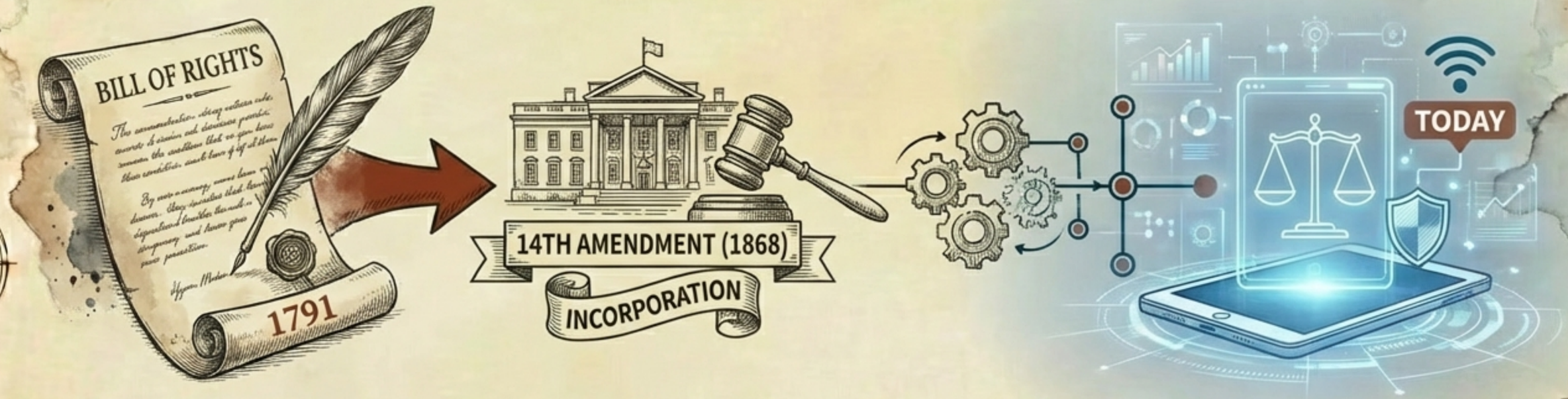
A Framework Built to Grow



EVOLUTION

Initially, the Bill of Rights only applied to the Federal government. It wasn't until the 14th Amendment (1868) and later Court decisions that these rights were applied to the states.

CONCLUSION

The conflict between Federalists and Antifederalists resulted in a stronger document that balances power with protection—a system that grows and changes with the nation.

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